The Eco Sentinels



AAVASSDITYA RAYA

DR BARKHA SUBBA, 41
Conservation scientist; Executive member, Federation of Societies for Environmental Protection
Darjeeling

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO
Winner of the 2026 Whitley Award, Barkha leads a grassroots conservation effort to save the endangered Himalayan amphibian

Saving the Salamander

For most people, the Himalayan salamander is an obscure amphibian native to the eastern Himalayas. For Dr Barkha Subba, it is a reminder that when nature disappears, entire ecosystems—and the communities that depend on them—begin to disappear too.

Subba spent a childhood filled with stories of mountains and wildlife narrated by her grandmother, and trips to forage in the woods. "I didn't dream of becoming a conservation scientist," she recalls with a smile. "I simply kept following my curiosity." A first-generation postgraduate in her family, Subba studied zoology before joining the Padmaja Naidu Himalayan Zoological Park for research. It was there that she became fascinated with the Himalayan salamander—a shy amphibian that emerges only during the monsoon and spends the rest of the year hidden underground.

Subba started working with the World Wide Fund for Nature (WWF) in Darjeeling during the pandemic, before launching an ambitious community-led conservation programme centred on the Himalayan salamander. She believes conservation can succeed not just with science but also trust, shared ownership and people's participation. Today, tea garden workers, villagers, schools and forest officials have all become partners in protecting the wetlands where the species breeds. That philosophy has won her the Green Oscar, or the Whitley Award, this year, bringing international attention—and crucial funding—to safeguard one of India's least-known species. ■

—Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

HER TAKE

"Stay curious and don't be afraid to pursue what genuinely interests you, even if the path is not always clear. Science and conservation need more women—not only as participants, but as researchers, leaders and decision-makers"